



JAMAICA CONSTABULARY FORCE
Policy and SOP for the Management of Attack against the Police

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1. Introduction

It has been argued in many fora in Jamaica whether the police should be treated any differently when injured in the line of duty, than any other citizen who has been a victim of crime. Many believe that a citizen makes his/her own decision to accept the job of a police officer with the full understanding of the risks involved, and as such should not expect any more attention and focused response to injury or fatality brought about during the conduct of his/her duty. Some argue that being agents of the state, an attack against the police should be seen as an attack against the state, and therefore should be given greater attention. There are also those who argue that equity in citizenship should translate to equal response to all cases of injuries and fatalities, whether or not the citizen is a member of either of the security forces.

- 1.1 The JCF's basis for this policy and standard operating procedure is not to seek to arrive at a resolution to the many and varied views on this matter. Rather, the aim is to standardize the JCF's response in such cases. True it is that members of the JCF operate in probably one of the most hostile environments in the world. There are inherent risk of hostility, and even deadly attacks against the police sometimes in carrying out a simple task. The always defensive stance that the police have to adapt makes it difficult to relax and remain composed for the entire tour of duty. It also adds to the volatility of the interactions between the police and citizens and hence easily results in undesirable (and sometimes unnecessary) confrontations.
- 1.2 Developing the culture of interactions characterized by resistance, defiance and hostile exchanges is unhealthy for the good order and rule of law of any society. In addition, it encourages impunity in those who have intentions of attacking the police.

2. Purpose

The aim of this policy guide is to develop an organizational response to incidents of attack against police during the conduct of duty. The intention is to provide support for the frontline officers with a view of helping to change the hostile environment within which they operate.

3. Scope

This policy and standard operating procedures apply to all sworn members of the JCF. It outlines the steps to be taken in the event of an attack on members and covers the management of welfare, communication with the family of affected members as well as the management of investigation.

4. Policy Statement

The Jamaica Constabulary Force will treat any incident involving an attack against a member as a major incident with a high priority. The organization will seek to protect and assure the member of unabated support, whilst at the same time speedily resolve an ongoing situation, and pursue all perpetrators with as much resources, including time, as is necessary to bring them to justice.

5. Responsibilities

Ownership within this context refers to the office that is responsible to see to the smooth and efficient execution of Investigation, Operation, Crime and Communication.

- 5.1 The Deputy Commissioners of Police Strategic Operations and Crime and Security have ownership of this policy and SOPs. All operational response will be coordinated by the Assistant Commissioner of Police, Operations Branch.
- 5.2 The Assistant Commissioner of Police Crime has oversight responsibility for the effective management of all investigative efforts.
- 5.3 The Director of Communication will have ownership of all media releases and internal communications.
- 5.4 Formation Commanders will have ownership of the following:
 - i. effective operational response;
 - ii. appropriate investigative response;
 - iii. pertinent communication response to the Director of Communications, whilst reporting to their respective Area and Branch Commanders.

6. Standard Operating Procedures

In the event that a member is attacked, injured or killed, in addition to the JCF's guidelines for treating with such situations, the following steps must be taken:

6.1 Immediate Action

- 6.1.1 A member of the police party involved or, where there is no other member, the first responder on the scene must immediately;
 - a) inform the PECC preferably by radio of the nature and location of the incident and any known information on the attacker
 - b) render first aid to injured member(s) in keeping with training
 - c) take all necessary and reasonable step to transport or cause injured member to be transported to the nearest medical facility
- 6.1.2 Upon receipt of the information, the PECC must;
 - a) ensure that the necessary support is deployed to counter the attack

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- b) coordinate and inform parties as different resources enter and exit the space
 - c) inform the Assistant Commissioner, Operations Branch of the development
 - d) inform the JDF where their member has been injured
- 6.1.3 The Assistant Commissioner of Police, Operations Branch must ensure that all necessary resources have been deployed to bring a timely and safe end to the situation
- 6.1.4 The scene must be cordoned, visited by the Scene of Crime Unit, and processed in accordance with the appropriate policies and standard operating procedures

6.2 Visit to injured members/Welfare Management

- 6.2.1 In case of injury to a member, the Deputy Commissioner of Police, Strategic Operations Portfolio, or the Assistant Commissioner of Police, Operations Branch or his or her designate who shall be a Superintendent of Police or above, must visit the member at the earliest possible visitation opportunity.
- 6.2.2 The head of the Formation to which the injured member is assigned must also visit the member at the earliest possible visitation opportunity.
- 6.2.3 The head of the Formation to which the injured member is assigned must coordinate with the JCF Welfare Officer, family members or next of kin of the injured member and other relevant offices/agencies on matters of member's welfare during the period of illness, including post-hospitalization.

6.3 Communication to family/next of kin in cases of injury of members

- 6.3.1 In case of injury, the head of the Formation to which the member is assigned or his/her designate who shall be of the rank of sergeant or above must inform the family/relative or next of kin of the incident.
- 6.3.2 Where the injured member resides in another Division, information may be coordinated through the Commanding Officer for the parish in which the injured member resides.
- 6.3.3 Every effort shall be made to inform the family/relative or next of kin, via personal visit and within the 12 hours of the incident. However, where a visit is not practicable or the situation warrants immediate family intervention, communication may be via telephone.
On no occasion shall communication be made via voice note or text message

6.4 Communication to family/next of kin in cases of death of members

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- 6.4.1 In case of death of a member, it is the responsibility of the Chaplain, the respective Area Assistant Chaplain or the Non-Geo Assistant Chaplain, the JCF Welfare Officer or a member not below the rank of superintendent to inform the family, relative or next of kin.
- 6.4.2 Every effort shall be made to inform the family/relative or next of kin, via personal visit and within the 12 hours of the incident. However, where a visit is not practicable, communication may be via telephone.
- 6.4.3 On no occasion shall communication be made via voice note or text message

6.5 Communication to the public

- 6.5.1 The Director of Communication must prepare and issue a media release on behalf of the Deputy Commissioner of Police, Strategic Operations Portfolio informing and assuring the citizens of the organization's resolve in ensuring the wellbeing of the member and bringing to justice the perpetrators.
- 6.5.2 The Director of Communication must ensure that progress on the investigation is communicated to the injured member and his/her family. All communications on the matter must be sanctioned and guided by the Director of Communication.

6.6 Management of Investigation

- 6.6.1 In all cases where a member is attacked, injured or killed, the Assistant Commissioner of Police, Crime must ensure that the investigation is managed and coordinated at the CIB HQ, and case conferences are conducted at that level.
- 6.6.2 A weekly report outlining *inter alia* the progress of the investigations and the injured member's health must be submitted to the Deputy Commissioner of Police, Strategic Operations Portfolio.